The Sneetches

By Theo Geisel (aka Dr. Suess)

NARRATOR: Now the Star-bellied Sneetches had bellies with stars.

The Plain-bellied Sneetches had none upon thars.

The stars weren't so big; they were really quite small.

You would think such a thing wouldn't matter at all.

But because they had stars, all the Star-bellied Sneetches would brag . . .

STAR BELLIED SNEETCHES: We're the best kind of Sneetch on the beaches.

NARRATOR: With their snoots in the air, they would sniff and they'd snort . . .

STAR BELLIED SNEETCHES: We'll have nothing to do with the plain-bellied sort.

NARRATOR: And whenever they met some, when they were out walking,

they'd hike right on past them without even talking.

INTRODUCTION

At first glance, The Sneetches by Theodor Seuss Geisel feels like a simple children's story -- bright creatures, ridiculous machines, and a problem as silly as stars on bellies. It invites us to laugh, to relax, to believe this is just another harmless rhyme.

But listen a little closer, and the humor starts to shift. Today division doesn't feel trivial. It feels constant. It feels loud. It feels uncomfortably real, as people sort themselves into political and moral parties and question the worth of others . . . And that's when the laughter at a silly children's story gets quiet.

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NARRATOR: When the Star-bellied children went out to play ball,

could the Plain-bellies join in their game? Not at all!

You could only play ball if your bellies had stars,

and the Plain-bellied children had none upon thars.

When the Star-bellied Sneetches had frankfurter roasts,

or picnics or parties or marshmallow toasts,

they never invited the Plain-bellied Sneetches.

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Left them out cold in the dark of the beaches.
Kept them away; never let them come near,
and that's how they treated them year after year.

Then one day, it seems, while the Plain-bellied Sneetches
were moping, just moping alone on the beaches,
sitting there, wishing their bellies had stars,
up zipped a stranger in the strangest of cars.

MCBEAN: My friends . . .

NARRATOR: He announced in a voice clear and keen

MCBEAN: My name is Sylvester McMonkey McBean.
I've heard of your troubles; I've heard you're unhappy.
But I can fix that; I'm the fix-it-up chappie.
I've come here to help you; I have what you need.
My prices are low, and I work with great speed,
and my work is one hundred percent guaranteed.

NARRATOR: Then quickly, Sylvester McMonkey McBean
put together a very peculiar machine.
Then he said . . .

MCBEAN: You want stars like a Star-bellied Sneetch?
My friends, you can have them . . . for three dollars each.
Just hand me your money and climb on aboard.

NARRATOR: They clambered inside and the big machine roared.
It bonked. It clonked. It jerked. It berked.
It bopped them around, but the thing really worked.

When the Plain-bellied Sneetches popped out, they had stars!
They actually did, they had stars upon thars!
Then they yelled at the ones who had stars from the start,

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PLAIN BELLIED SNEETCHES: We're exactly like you; you can't tell us apart.
We're all just the same now, you snooty old smarties.
Now we can come to your frankfurter parties!

STAR BELLIED SNEETCHES: Good grief! We're still the best Sneetches, and they are the worst.
But how in the world will we know
if which kind is what or the other way 'round?

NARRATOR: Then up stepped McBean with a very sly wink, and he said . . .

MCBEAN: Things are not quite as bad as you think.
You don't know who's who, that is perfectly true.
But come with me, friends, do you know what I'll do?
I'll make you again the best Sneetches on beaches,
and all it will cost you is ten dollars eaches.
Belly stars are no longer in style.
What you need is a trip through my stars-off machine.
This wondrous contraption will take off your stars,
so you won't look like Sneetches who have them on thars.

NARRATOR: That handy machine, working very precisely,
removed all the stars from their bellies quite nicely.
Then, with snoots in the air, they paraded about.
They opened their beaks and proceeded to shout . . .

STAR BELLIED SNEETCHES: We now know who's who, and there isn't a doubt,
the best kind of Sneetches are Sneetches without.

NARRATOR: Then, of course those with stars all got frightfully mad.
To be wearing a star now was frightfully bad.
Then, of course old Sylvester McMonkey McBean
invited them into his stars-off machine.
Then, of course from then on, you can probably guess,
things really got into a horrible mess.

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All the rest of the day on those wild screaming beaches,
the Fix-it-up-Chappie was fixing up Sneetches.
Off again, on again, in again, out again,
through the machine and back round about again,
still paying money, still running through,
changing their stars every minute or two,
until neither the Plain- nor the Star-bellies knew
whether this one was that one or that one was this one
or which one was what one or what one was who!

Then, when every last cent of their money was spent,
the Fix-It-Up-Chappie packed up and he went.
And he laughed as he drove in his car up the beach. . .

MCBEAN: They never will learn; no, you can't teach a Sneetch!"

NARRATOR: But McBean was quite wrong, I'm quite happy to say,
the Sneetches got quite a bit smarter that day.
That day, they decided that Sneetches are Sneetches,
and no kind of Sneetch is the ***BEST*** on the beaches.
That day, all the Sneetches forgot about stars,
and whether they had one or not upon thars.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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